Study Guide for the Oral Midterm Exam

ECON 623, American Economic History, Fall 2026

- **Date and sign-up.** The oral midterm is on Monday 19 October during our class time, 4:30–7:10 PM. Sign up for one 15-minute slot in the Canvas calendar. Open Calendar in Canvas, click Find Appointment on the right, choose this course, and reserve a slot. Sign up from a laptop or desktop because the Canvas app may not show the appointments. If your Disability Services accommodation gives you extra time on exams sign up for one slot and email me. I will hold the following slot for you, and I need the accommodation form before the exam.
- **Zoom or in person.** You may take the exam on Zoom or in person in my office, Buchanan Hall D159. When you reserve your slot type Zoom or In person in the comment box. The Zoom link is in the appointment details in Canvas. Join at the start of your slot and not before because another student may still be finishing. If you come in person wait outside the office until I call you in.
- **Equipment.** On Zoom take the exam on a laptop or desktop computer with your camera on. Phones are not allowed. You will draw diagrams on the Zoom whiteboard so practice using it before the exam. In person you will draw diagrams by hand and I will supply paper and pens.
- **Notes.** You may have your notes and the readings open. I will ask you to explain each answer so a diagram copied from your notes without an explanation earns little credit.
- **Format and grading.** I will ask three questions. Two are on the guaranteed topics below. I choose the third and it can be on any reading or lecture from Weeks 1–6. I grade each question out of 20 as you answer and tell you your grade at the end of the exam. The midterm is 30 percent of the course grade.
- **Guaranteed topic 1. Cities (Week 6).** Explain the three theories of why cities are where they are (locational fundamentals, increasing returns and random growth) and what each predicts after a shock to a city. Be ready to draw those predictions on the whiteboard. Then explain what Davis and Weinstein (2002) learn from the bombing of Japanese cities, what Bleakley and Lin (2012) learn from the portage sites that railroads made obsolete, and what the two papers establish together that neither establishes alone.
- **Guaranteed topic 2. Allen and Clark (Week 5).** Explain Allen's (2011) account of why the Industrial Revolution began in Britain and Clark's (1987) account of why output per worker in cotton mills differed across countries. Then put the two papers against each other. Clark argues that the wage is a poor measure of what labor costs a firm. Explain what that implies for Allen's argument that wages high relative to the prices of capital and energy made labor-saving machines profitable in Britain.